

Review: Işıkara & Mokre, Marx's Value Theory at the Frontiers (2026)

reviewed against the grand canonical framework

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Review: Işıkara & Mokre, *Marx's Theory of Value at the Frontiers* (Routledge, 2026), read against the grand canonical framework

Produced 2026-07-06 by a review agent reading the book PDF (221 pp.) against *qmd/consolidated_framework.qmd* and *qmd/grand_canonical_cpe.qmd*. Chapters read in full: front matter + Introduction (pp. 1–17), ch. 3 (pp. 48–74), ch. 4 (pp. 75–126), ch. 5 (pp. 127–179), appendices (pp. 180–203).

Preliminary correction of the record. The book is not the 2022 ROPE paper scaled up — it supersedes it on three axes. The dataset is EXIOBASE 3.8.2, 159 industries × 44 countries × 26 years (1995–2020), not WIOD 42 countries 2000–2017 (p. 49); the model now includes fixed capital flows via the Södersten–Lenzen capital-flow matrices (p. 54); and the normalization has moved from within-country to the global level, with an international profit rate and country-differential wage rates (pp. 55, 57). The acknowledgments confirm the lineage from the 2022 ROPE paper and the Shaikh supervision at the New School (p. xiii). Decisive for citation: they explicitly bracket the transformation-problem debates and the New Interpretation — “we do not delve into those debates... The works of Rubin and Shaikh are the cornerstones” (p. 13).

1. The measurement framework of Chapter 3 (pp. 48–74)

Price vectors. Three vectors per industry-country-year: direct prices (proportional to vertically integrated labor values), production prices, market prices. Labor values are $v = gl(I-A-D)^{-1}$ (eq. 3.2, p. 56), where D is a depreciation-flow matrix (not a stock; p. 54) and gl is a skill-adjusted direct labor vector: hours weighted by the industry wage relative to the global average wage (eq. 3.1, p. 55), following Shaikh–Glenn and Rotta. Production prices: $pp = (1 - r/R) v (I - R(r/R)H)^{-1}$ with $H = (A+D)(I-A-D)^{-1}$ (eq. 3.3, p. 56) — the Shaikh/Tsoufidis–Tsaliki closure $w = 1 - r/R$ (identical to the framework’s equation). The international variant puts the country rate r_c in the wage term and the global rate in the H term (eq. 3.4, p. 57). There is no MELT in the book —

values are monetized by normalizing labor content by the global average value–price ratio (eqs. 3.6/5.5, pp. 58, 149), a global-MELT direct price in the Ochoa–Shaikh tradition, never named or theorized as such, deliberately not the NI MELT.

Deviation measures. MAD, MAWD, CV, numeraire-free Euclidean distance (eq. 3.9, p. 60); headline is MAWD with market prices in the denominator (eq. 3.10, p. 61). Nonproduction, nonprofit and recycling industries excluded on Shaikh–Tonak grounds (p. 63); appendix 3.A.2 (p. 182) shows the excluded categories deviate far more (recycling ~29%, nonprofit ~24%).

Findings. Mean MAWD: market–direct 14.14%, market–production 13.20%, production–direct 2.89% (Table 3.1, p. 62); MP–DP in the 10–20% band “in almost all countries” (p. 63), PP–DP below 5% everywhere — Ricardo’s 7% bound vindicated (pp. 63, 71). Log-log three-way FE regressions: slopes 1.001–1.0025, $R^2 \approx 0.99$ (Table 3.2, p. 64). The cross-country dispersion pattern in Table 3.1 is the framework’s calorimetric core–periphery gradient in their data: US 8.62, France 9.57, Slovenia 9.78, Italy 10.00 at the cool end; Norway 27.86, Greece 26.92, Türkiye 24.64, Mexico 23.13, Cyprus 22.35, Lithuania 22.14, China 21.46 at the hot end. Note Norway: the hottest economy in the sample is a rent economy, not a peripheral one.

The turbulence test (§3.6, their genuinely novel contribution). Mueller (1986)/Vaona (2011) method: deviations regressed on intercept + $1/t$, $1/t^2$, $1/t^3$ with country FE and clustered errors (eqs. 3.11–3.12, pp. 67–68). “Gravitation” = no significant deterministic component; “convergence” = significant trend, nonsignificant intercept. Results (Table 3.4, p. 69): 85 production industries gravitate (66%), 33 converge (25%), 11 no participation (9%); >90% of production industries, 75% of gross output, participate in turbulent equalization. Nonparticipants (Table 3.5, p. 69): paddy rice, crude oil, petroleum refining, chemicals n.e.c., fabricated metals, electricity distribution, rail, mail/telecom, R&D, education, health — rent-bearing and state-dominated sectors (pp. 69–70).

2. Does their setup support the panel wedge–dispersion test? Yes — mostly by replication

Dispersion per country-year is already computed in their pipeline (p. 61, n. 5, p. 71). Panel: 44 countries $\times$ 26 years $\approx$ 1,144 cells, ample for country FE. The wedge $r^*(1-s)$ is constructible from the same EXIOBASE releases (gross operating surplus over VA per country, p. 57; GFCF/depreciation in the same tables). The panel test is not actually blocked: the book’s methods sections (3.3–3.4, 4.6.2, 5.3.1) specify the pipeline completely enough to rebuild by extending `exiobase_thermo.R` to 1995–2020.

Still worth requesting from the authors: (i) the computed country-year-industry price-vector panel (mp' , pp' , dp') or generating code (computations ran at WU Vienna, p. xiii — processed matrices exist); (ii) processed Södersten–Lenzen D matrices per year (n. 4, p. 71); (iii) per-country-year MAWD series behind Table 3.1.

Design warnings for the regression: (1) rent contamination — land use and resource extraction significantly shift MP–PP deviations (within- R^2 0.176, Table 5.2, p. 155); resource economies have both high operating surplus and high dispersion (Norway) — include their e_0' , e_1' , e_2'

resource-intensity controls (eq. 5.8, pp. 150–51) or the wedge regression has an omitted variable correlated with the regressor. (2) Skill-adjustment endogeneity — their direct prices embed relative wages, mechanically coupled to the wage structure inside the wedge; run robustness with unadjusted hours. (3) Interpolation — EXIOBASE interpolates between benchmarks (p. 52); cluster by country. (4) Their deviations are percentage-point MAWDs, not log-dispersion — the framework’s 2019 value of 1.07 at 9,800-product resolution vs their 0.13 at 159 industries is mostly aggregation/metric artifact (see tension 1).

3. Turbulent gravitation and the zeroth law: strong match, three frictions

Their competition theory (pp. 50–51, 60, 66–68, 76, 88) is Shaikhian real competition — the framework’s thermal-contact zeroth law with finite conductivity. Table 3.5’s nonparticipating industries are a measured conductivity map: thermal contact is broken exactly in rent-insulated and state-administered sectors, as the framework predicts (walls and reservoir-pinned sectors sit outside the equalization channel). They import the fluid-dynamics definition of turbulence (Ferziger & Perić, pp. 51, 67).

Frictions: (i) the center of gravity moves (p. 67) — the FS linearization around a fixed long-period position is a stationarity idealization; the honest statement is that the NESS is locally stationary between technique changes. (ii) The law of value is not an equilibrium price theory (pp. 60, 66, 70) — “equilibrium” vocabulary must always be glossed as gravitation around a never-attained state. (iii) No dynamics in the book — no Hamiltonian, no conservation claim, no cross-dual model; the turbulence test is purely statistical. Cite them for the stationary object, never for the forcing mechanism.

4. Value transfers and the Onsager mapping: incidence yes, reciprocity no

Central object: $\delta = pp^* - dp$ (eq. 4.1, p. 101), decomposed via four counterfactual price systems (Table 4.7, eq. 4.15, p. 106) into δ_1 (value-composition-induced) and δ_2 (rate-of-surplus-value-induced). Closed form eq. 4.7 (p. 102) is exactly the framework’s “standing thermodynamic force”: a technique-rooted composition gradient plus an exploitation-rate gradient, manifested as a stationary deviation profile. Headlines: transfers = 5.9% of global gross production annually, >€70 trillion cumulative 1995–2020 (pp. 107, 118); VCC and RSV channels nearly equal globally (3.01 vs 2.90 pts; Table 4.8, p. 108) — rejecting Emmanuel’s wage-differential primacy (p. 118); receivers concentrated in Japan, US, China, Italy, Britain; Mexico and Indonesia transfer out >50% of the value their production industries create (Table 4.9, p. 109); China switches from net payer to net receiver ~2005–2010, VCC channel first (pp. 112–13). Nonproduction value capture across borders: only 0.15% of global production, ~20× smaller than transfers, with underestimation caveats (pp. 115–19).

Mapping: their δ is the incidence structure — the stationary temperature profile, the incidence half of the U decomposition. The reciprocity test (L_{kj} vs L_{jk}) is absent: they never construct bilateral response coefficients or test symmetry. Their data supports it; the Onsager measurement remains to be done. Their two channels are separated only by model counterfactuals and contaminate each other (“unequal exchange in the broad sense always permeates unequal

exchange in the strict sense,” p. 103) — the clean force decomposition faces the same entanglement in data.

The wealth/value firewall: fully theirs. §5.4.3 (pp. 168–70) is the strongest published statement of the two-ledger discipline: circulation in exchange values vs “the mirroring circulation in the qualitative domain of use values, including flows of matter and energy” (p. 169); EUE endorsed as mapping, denied explanatory standing (“a descriptive tool that fails to explain the patterns it studies,” p. 169); Hornborg’s error diagnosed (p. 169, n. 44 p. 175); bees, horses, fossil fuels do useful work but not abstract labor (p. 170). The only “thermodynamics” in the book is Hornborg’s phrase “the thermodynamics of imperialism,” quoted in order to be criticized (p. 168) — the S3 substrate-promotion shift rejected by the authors. An asset (the framework rejects the same move) but it defines the burden of proof: the formalism must be visibly a form-analogy of ledgers, or these are the referees who will kill it.

5. Ecology, rent, and ϕ : incidence measured — one real challenge to the Ricardian margin

Rent in all three forms (absolute, differential I/II, monopoly; §§5.2.2–5.2.4, pp. 133–40) is redistributed surplus value, never a creation channel (pp. 131, 155) — exactly the framework’s rent discipline. Their sentence to cite when introducing ϕ : “rent... is internal to the law of value... not an exception to or negation of the latter but a frontier to it” (p. 171).

Empirically, the first measured incidence map of the ϕ channel: land use and resource extraction (e_0) positively shift MP–PP deviations, while indirect downstream use (e_2) shows large negative coefficients — gas -106.7 , metal ores -50.5 (Table 5.2, p. 155): rents are paid out of negative deviations in the non-extracting industries (pp. 155–56) — the cross-sectional footprint of the Gibbs–Duhem ecological squeeze $dr|_w = -(N/K)d\phi$, distributed through the input network. China and the US the biggest net rent payers; Russia, India, Norway, Greece, Malta net receivers (pp. 156–58, Tables 5.B.1–5.B.2). Metabolic rift/shift apparatus (§5.4.2, pp. 162–67; turnover time vs replenishment time, pp. 165, 167) is a narrative sibling of the third-law/entropy-export story.

The challenge: absolute rent vs the no-rent margin. The framework pins ϕ “at the Ricardian no-rent margin”; the book’s rent theory holds that under absolute rent even the worst plot pays rent — landed property as collective monopoly forces market price above production price by withholding land (pp. 133–35), the level set by supply–demand and class struggle (p. 135); scarcity itself “socially produced” (p. 162). The grand canonical structure survives (a monopolized reservoir is still a reservoir) but the Ricardian marginal determination of ϕ does not. Fix (cheap, strengthening): ϕ is reservoir-pinned, with the no-rent margin as the competitive special case and absolute/monopoly rent as the monopolized-reservoir case with a bargaining component; citation apparatus pp. 133–42 (incl. the Bortkiewicz–Emmanuel resolution: absolute rent in form, monopoly rent in content, p. 141). Then Table 3.5 reads: where the reservoir is monopolized, thermal contact is partially severed — a unification the book gestures at (pp. 69–70, 150) but cannot state.

6. Points of tension, stated adversarially

1. The calorimetry number is not their calorimetry number. 2019 output-weighted log dispersion 1.07 at 9,800 products vs their MAWD ~ 0.13 at 159 industries — same order of measurement read by them as “remarkably small” deviations (p. 49). Dispersion moments are savagely resolution- and metric-dependent. Before publishing “dispersion = susceptibility,” a scaling analysis across aggregation levels and a declared metric are mandatory. Table 3.A.1 (pp. 180–81) hands over four metrics per country to start.
2. No MELT, no New Interpretation (p. 13). Zero support for the MELT-as-k_B bridge; they chose Rubin–Shaikh over Duménil–Foley deliberately. Cite them for measurement, never for the MELT.
3. Their labor is not homogeneous hours. Skill adjustment weights hours by relative wages (eq. 3.1) — quietly imports the monetary ledger into the labor ledger, a ledger-discipline violation by the framework’s own standards. Defend homogeneous hours or show robustness to both conventions.
4. VCC vs OCC. They argue the organic composition category is inappropriate internationally (pp. 89–90; n. 33, p. 122). There is no “uniform-OCC reference state” in the book — the reference is direct prices, and “prices = values” internationally requires uniform VCC and uniform rates of surplus value simultaneously (their eq. 4.7 is literally this statement). Re-state the ideal limit accordingly; stop attributing the reference-state construction to them.
5. A quarter of industries converge rather than gravitate, and the center moves (Table 3.4, p. 69). The FS stationary-response interpretation assumes the gravitational regime; the panel test should condition on their gravitation/convergence classification.
6. Rent explains a significant minority of dispersion (within- R^2 0.176) and is correlated with profit rates — tension for the wedge regression; if the panel is null after rent controls, ch. 5 supplies the rival explanation of dispersion structure the framework would have to live with.
7. Historical-specificity policing. Fetishism = identifying “social conditions with physical things” (p. 131); the law of value holds “only under certain conditions” (p. 5); abstract labor requires the dual freedom of the laborer (p. 159). Best defense is already in the architecture: the identification refuses serfdom and slavery because unfree labor has no chemical potential — their p. 159 argument in formal dress. Lead with their measurements, not the dictionary (red flag 8).
8. Vocabulary discipline. Countries and industries cannot exploit one another; transfers between capitals are appropriation, not exploitation (pp. 85, 94–95). Say “drain” or “transfer,” never “exploitation of the periphery.”

7. Verdict

Cite FOR: (a) the deviation-calorimetry measurement protocol and dataset (pp. 49, 56–62, Table 3.1, appendix 3.A); (b) the turbulent-equalization test as the empirical zeroth law, with Table 3.5 as the conductivity/wall map (pp. 66–71); (c) the δ_1/δ_2 transfer decomposition as the closest empirical relative of the U-incidence object — 5.9% of global production, Emmanuel refuted, the China regime switch (pp. 101–13, 118–19); (d) rent as internal frontier of the law of value, Table 5.2 as the ϕ -channel incidence incl. downstream negative deviations as the distributed

ecological squeeze (pp. 146–58, 171); (e) the wealth/value firewall and anti-Hornborg argument (pp. 168–70); (f) absolute rent as corrective to a naively Ricardian ϕ (pp. 133–42).

Do NOT lean on it for: the MELT / NI (bracketed, p. 13); Onsager reciprocity (never constructed); Hamiltonian dynamics (absent); homogeneous-hours values (theirs are wage-weighted); the “uniform-OCC ideal gas” as their construction; “small deviations” as a resolution-independent stylized fact.

Three concrete next actions. 1. Run the wedge–dispersion panel by replication (extend `exiobase_thermo.R` to 1995–2020 per eqs. 3.1–3.8, D per Södersten–Lenzen; both MAWD and log metrics; country FE; e_o', e_i', e_z' rent controls; skill-adjustment robustness pair), with a parallel data request to Işıkara (NYU) and Mokre (computations ran at WU Vienna — processed matrices exist). 2. Fix `references.bib`: `isikaramokre2022` verified correct against the book’s bibliography (p. 72) — RoPE 34(1), 165–80, 2022, DOI 10.1080/09538259.2021.1904648. Add the book (Routledge 2026, DOI 10.4324/9781003398929, ISBN 978-1-032-50538-1). Later, as used: Södersten & Lenzen (2020, ESR 32(4)), Rotta (2025, EPA), Hickel–Hanbury Lemos–Barbour (2024, Nat. Comms 15:6298), Tsoulfidis & Tsaliki (2019). 3. Reconcile the calorimetry before publishing it: recompute 2019 dispersion at 159-industry resolution in MAWD units; produce the dispersion-vs-aggregation scaling curve; rewrite the manuscript’s Işıkara–Mokre sentences to cite the book, attribute the reference state correctly (uniform VCC and uniform exploitation rate), and add the rent-control caveat to P3/P4 — Table 5.2 is simultaneously the best supporting measurement and the most dangerous omitted variable.